

HOLY ROMAN EMPIRE



FOR MORE THAN 800 years, most of central Europe was loosely tied together in the Holy Roman Empire, an attempt to revive the old Roman empire, with backing from the Christian Church. It was founded in 962.

After 1273, the Habsburg family of Austria won the throne and dominated the empire from then on. The emperors were elected by seven German princes and crowned by the Pope in Rome. The emperor had little power, but the title made him political leader of Europe.

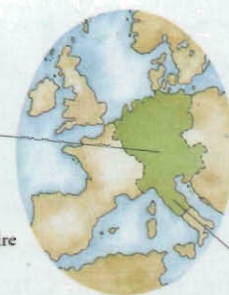
Crown is set with enamel plaques.

10th-century imperial crown



Otto's German lands

The empire in 987



Emperors were also kings of Italy.

The empire

From its foundation in 962 until the mid-13th century, the Holy Roman Empire included much of Germany, the Low Countries, Switzerland, Austria, and northern Italy. Over the next centuries, it shrank, but it remained dominant in Germany.

Otto I: the birth of empire

In 936, Otto, a descendant of Charlemagne, became king of Germany. He defeated the Magyar invaders at the battle of Lech in 955 and went on to conquer northern Italy. In 962, the Pope crowned him Holy Roman Emperor.

Habsburgs

The Habsburgs took their name from a castle in Switzerland and held vast estates in Switzerland, Austria, and southern Germany. In 1273, a member of the Habsburg family became Rudolf I of Germany and then the Holy Roman Emperor. With a few short breaks, the Habsburgs ran the empire until its end in 1806. Under their rule, the interests of the empire were secondary to those of increasing Habsburg family power.

Maximilian I married Mary of Burgundy in 1477 and acquired Burgundy.

Philip I, son of Maximilian, married Juana of Castile and Aragon in 1496.

Mary of Burgundy



Charles's brother, Ferdinand I, married Anna and inherited Bohemia and Hungary.

Charles V, son of Philip, inherited Spain through his mother, Juana and the Habsburg lands from his grandfather Maximilian.

Struggle for power

The emperor was the supreme secular (worldly) ruler of Christian Europe; the Pope was its supreme spiritual ruler. The two often clashed. In 1076, Pope Gregory VII deposed Emperor Henry IV. The conflict led to a decline in the power of the emperors over the next few centuries.

Charles V

Habsburg power in Europe reached its peak in 1519, when Charles V (1500–58) became emperor. He acquired vast lands from each of his grandparents, including Spain and its empire in America. Charles kept this empire together until 1556, when he gave up the throne and divided his empire between his brother Ferdinand, who became emperor on Charles's death in 1558, and his son Philip, who ruled Spain, Italy, and the Low Countries.



Ornate Renaissance decoration



The Schweizertor, a gate to the Hofburg

Imperial Vienna

The Habsburg capital was the Austrian city of Vienna. It was one of the leading cities in Europe, with fine churches, palaces, and other civic buildings. The centre of Habsburg power was the Hofburg Palace, a vast complex including imperial apartments and government offices.

Maria Theresa

In 1740, Emperor Charles VI died, leaving his daughter Maria Theresa on the throne. Prussia and France disputed her right to inherit the throne and declared war. Maria was an inspired leader and managed to keep her empire together, making Austria into a powerful, centralized state.



Timeline

800 Charlemagne crowned.

962 Otto, king of Germany, becomes first Holy Roman Emperor.

1076 Pope overthrows emperor Henry IV and establishes papal power over emperor.

1273 Rudolf I becomes first emperor from the Habsburg family.



Imperial knight

1517 Reformation under Martin Luther results in a divide between German Protestant princes and the Catholic emperor.

1519 Charles V is crowned emperor and becomes most powerful man in Europe.

1556 Charles splits his empire between brother Ferdinand and son Philip; Habsburg Austria dominates the Holy Roman empire.

1806 Francis II abolishes the Holy Roman empire.

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